

THE ESTABLISHMENT

Inner Workings of a Secret Cabal

Storybook

For a low-ink print and play



The United Earth Nations are angry with Queen Belle's attempt to control the entire outer system, especially her occupation of Titan. The Treaty of Utgard, which had created an uneasy truce between the Earth and the Jovian Kingdom, has been terminated. Earth would like Ceres' cooperation instituting a blockade between the inner and outer systems.

1

Remain Neutral (2)

"Trade with the outer planets is important to Ceres' future. We can't afford to upset Queen Belle and must remain neutral in this dispute."

Side with Earth (3)

"Earth will pay our captains to support this blockade. It could bring in a lot of money and resources into Ceres if we support them."

Earth attempted the blockade on their own. It was unsuccessful without support from Ceres. They abandoned the attempted shortly after. Earth tucked her tail between her legs and waited for a future opportunity.



A popular singer-turned-humanitarian, Tyesha, has begun her “We are the Worlds” tour. She is traveling to Venus, Earth, Mars, and Ceres. The tour’s popular message encourages people from all nations to accept one another. In response, politicians propose an interplanetary governmental forum.

2

Do what the people want (4)

“Polls show overwhelming public support for joining the summit. Most citizens believe that interstellar cooperation can lead to greater stability and a brighter future.”

Side with economists (5)

“Economists have proven that foreign companies will replace locals if we work too closely with other planets and will cause major loss of employment.”

Ceres teamed up with Earth to create a naval blockade through the asteroid belt. In response, the Jovian Kingdom enacted an economic embargo against Earth and is attempting to break its alliances. These acts are negatively affecting all their economies.



During a routine shipment of ore, Earth's defensive missiles shot down a Cerian ship, the Tattered Flag. Earth claims that the ship refused to identify itself and that they detected dangerous materials. According to Martian civilian ships, the Flag previously reported having network issues and that they may have spotted a Jovian ship nearby.

3

Investigate with Earth (6)

"This could have been a trick of Jovian spies. Let's work cooperatively with Earth to investigate the root cause of the incident and make an informed decision."

Break the alliance (7)

"Earth is getting trigger-happy with their increasing paranoia. And this embargo is hurting our economy. This is a great excuse to break off this alliance."

Friendly nations held the first Interplanetary Government Summit at the Space Station, Calypso. Representatives from the three largest human settlements attended. Subsequently, the leaders of Mars, Earth, and Ceres built an alliance. Venus opted to stay neutral.



The Enceladus colony, an isolationist human settlement on a moon of Saturn, has discovered a method to create a powerful energy source using their plentiful supply of molecular hydrogen at the Robinson Refinery. They claim it's a clean energy source for supporting life. However, physicists warn it could be used as a weapon.

4

Create a federation (8)

"Let's use this breakthrough to invite the outer planets into our alliance. A federation of all human settlements can lead us into the future. Humanity should work together for the benefit of all."

Build up defenses (9)

"We know Queen Belle is going to take over the Robinson refinery and use that energy source to attack us. We need to put money and resources into protection against her aggression."

While the immediate threat between planets cooled, Ceres walked a fine line between the inner and outer planets. The Summit occurred without Ceres' participation. From all accounts, it was rather successful and there were talks of forming a federation.



A routine scan of the Belt discovered a cloaked satellite. Scientists retrieved and studied it for further information. The unit could take long-distance photographs, capture audio waves, and send them back to its planet of origin. Earth, Mars, and the Jovian Kingdom all deny spying.

5

Become isolationists (10)

"Ceres needs to protect ourselves from the outside worlds. This recent incident is proof that they are out to get us. We need to exit from the interstellar stage so we can focus on ourselves."

Engage in espionage (11)

"Whoever is spying must have nefarious plans for us in the future. The prudent and safest thing to do is to turn the tables and to spy on them."

Together, Earth and Ceres track down the Jovian ship, the Hydra. They discovered it had the technology to interfere with communications. Queen Belle refused to admit wrongdoing in the Tattered Flag incident. She maintains that the Hydra is an independent rogue vessel.



In retaliation for the Tattered Flag incident, Earth declares war on the Jovian Kingdom. Naval skirmishes often occur in the Main Belt and threaten Cerian mining operations. During the battle of 16 Psyche, forces obliterated the entire resource-rich asteroid.

6

Allow Jovians through (12)

“We need to redirect this action elsewhere. Space is an enormous area. If we ‘accidentally’ allow Jovian ships through the Belt, the inner planets will get the action and leave us safe.”

Impound Jovian ships (13)

“We know the terrain and outnumber them. Let’s impound any Jovians that come near the Belt. Let’s stop the fighting before it starts.”

Ceres informed Earth of the desire to become neutral in their disagreements with the Jovian Kingdom. The change upset Earth. They accused Ceres of staging the incident to break the alliance.



Full-out war breaks out between the inner and outer planets. Ceres is caught in the middle. While the inner planets are closer and offer stability, there is much more opportunity among the outer planets for growth and trade.

7

Side with Outers (14)

"It's only a matter of time until the Queen takes over the entire system. If we get in good with her now, we'll have the advantage over the rest who fought the inevitable."

Side with Inners (15)

"Earth has a stronger Navy, and Mars soldiers are the best in the galaxy. It would be suicide to go against them."

The Terran Federation is a political union of the self-governing human settlements of Earth, Ceres, Mars, and the Kingdom of Jupiter. The Enceladus colony signed on as a protectorate. The Federation offers security and stability for all its members.



An environmental crisis on Europa has led to a dramatic number of refugees. As a member of the Federation, the Jovian Kingdom is reaching out for help. Ceres agreed to take in some, but the added demand on their welfare system is creating economic and social distress.

8

Take more refugees (16)

“While these added refugees may create challenges, we know that the Federation will support us when it’s needed most. We must stand by our word.”

Withdraw from federation (17)

“Ceres is in the grips of a crisis because we have lost autonomy over our own government. Taking refugees is causing a disruption in the law and order of the entire Belt.”

The Calypso Collective Defense Agreement dictates that should any foreign power attack either Earth, Mars, Ceres or Enceladus, they will come to each other's defense. They also agreed to settle international disputes through non-violent means, so they do not endanger international peace, security, and justice.



Queen Belle's forces invade Enceladus and claim it as part of the Jovian Kingdom. The independent settlement does not have a protective force to keep her military out. They look to the others within the Calypso Defense Agreement to assist.

9

Use force (18)

"We cannot let the Queen have control over this weapon. Her invading forces need to be repelled at all costs."

Use diplomacy (19)

"We should settle this like civilized humans. Let's use diplomatic channels to come to an agreement with the Kingdom and Enceladus."

Ceres saw relative peace by avoiding outside politics and limiting contact with foreign nations. She achieved political independence, economic self-reliance, and military autonomy. Avoiding foreign affairs allowed Ceres to focus on domestic issues and policy. Ceres experienced impressive social and economic growth.



A Martian patrol ship in the Main Belt stopped the Cerian mining vessel, the Bisbee, and forced her to give up her load. Mars depends on the elements found in the asteroid belt and claimed that area of the belt as their property. They accused Ceres of trespassing. The Bisbee returned home without mined materials.

10

Seek Earth's help (20)

"We have done well avoiding foreign influence, but we cannot take on a power like Mars alone. Let's reach out to Earth and seek her help in settling this matter before it becomes violent."

Take on Mars alone (21)

"We are a great and mighty state because we have always stood strong alone. Now we must show the rest of the worlds that we will not idly stand by as Mars steals our livelihood from us."

Through a variety of methods, Ceres identified five targets for espionage, including natural resources, popular sentiment, economics, military capability, and counterintelligence. Agents report back intelligence that gives a clear picture of the other planets and their secrets.



An undercover agent has delivered files proving that Earth is planning a surprise attack on Ganymede, a moon of Jupiter. A successful attack would mean Earth could destabilize the Kingdom. Ceres has a tumultuous relationship with the Jovians. However, they have a lot in common to build a positive relationship.

11

Warn the Kingdom (22)

"If Earth takes on the Jovian Kingdom, we might be next. We should take this opportunity to strengthen our relationship with Queen Belle by alerting her of Earth's intentions."

Blackmail Earth (23)

"We should tell Earth that we know the truth and use it as leverage to get them to do what we say, or we will reveal their secret."

Blockade captains were secretly told to allow some Jovians ships through their defenses and to erase any log of seeing them. Naval battles moved closer to Mars and Earth and spared the Belt from any major action.



As the war continues, Earth is low on ships and soldiers. She recruits by force through impressment. People who left Earth to work on Ceres were technically still Earth citizens. The Terran Navy boards merchant ships, ransacking them and taking the ship and crew into service.

12

Declare war on Earth (24)

“Enough is enough. Our people don’t deserve to be treated like this. We need to force Earth into realizing these inhumane practices can no longer go on.”

Join Earth navy (25)

“This will all go away once the war has ended. Let’s support Earth by sending whatever mercenaries we can muster and pay them to join the Earth’s navy.”

The people of Ceres formed the Cerian Homeland Security Force by recruiting willing captains and mercenaries. The Force patrolled the Belt and took any Jovian ship by force. They were very successful because of their deep knowledge of the Belt and readily available resources. Eventually, it became too costly for the Queen to continue the war with Earth.



General discontent with the Jovian monarchy and poor post-war economic policies leads to social unrest among the Queen's subjects. Meanwhile, Ceres is now the greatest naval power in the system. A vocal minority among the asteroids is pushing for an outward expansion.

13

Destroy the Kingdom (26)

"The Queen never admitted their part in the Tattered Flag incident. Now it's our turn to use our strength and take over her Kingdom."

Usurp the Queen (27)

"An absolute monarchy is an atrocious way to govern and should never have left Earth. Let us free the states within the Kingdom and support their independence."

Ceres joined the outer planets and attacked Earth's moon, Luna. It ended up the greatest military mistake of the war. Ceres' make-shift army was no match for the oldest, best-trained military force. The news of the loss devastated Ceres. Shortly thereafter, a fleet of Earth ships arrived at her doorstep demanding surrender.



An armistice established the end of hostilities between the Inner and Outer planets. As part of a permanent treaty, Earth demanded that Mars accept blame for escalating the war, admit the Tattered Flag incident was only a mistake, pay repatriations, and dismantle her military.

14

Negotiate the terms (28)

"We must not accept these terms. We will be bankrupted, humiliated, and defenseless. Earth intends to make us suffer for something they started. Let us ask Venus to step in on our behalf and negotiate more favorable terms."

Ceres takes blame(29)

"We have no choice but to accept these terms. Our people are starving, exhausted, and want an end to the fighting. We have no allies left to aid us, and no means to restart this war, even if we wanted. We must accept and move on."

Ceres joined the inner planets in the Sol Interplanetary War. The resource-rich asteroids served as supply centers for Earth and Martian ships. The Belt itself served as a hiding place for Inner Forces to engage in guerilla warfare.



Without Ceres, the Jovian Kingdom could not keep up supply lines to fuel the war and had to concede. The two factions signed an armistice on Ceres. All eyes were on the central power to determine the next step in interplanetary relations.

15

Push for an alliance (30)

“This is our chance to broker peace among all humankind. We can keep the peace between the two through fair trade and diplomacy.”

Push for domination (31)

“War will just happen again if we don’t take the reins. Let’s assert our dominance over everyone by controlling trade and enforcing the policies we want. We are the gatekeepers of the solar system.”

Epilogue

Ceres struggled for a time integrating the influx of refugees, but theirs had always been a planet of immigrants. By welcoming a diverse group of people, Ceres made great advancements in technology and the arts.

Ari Horowitz, an European refugee and brilliant physicist, settled on Ceres. They discovered the means for faster-than-light space travel while working for a Cerian mining company. The Horowitz drive enabled Ceres to be the first to travel past the known solar system and to begin a new chapter of human history.

16

Epilogue

Ceres faced low economic growth, stagnating incomes, and an economic system at a breaking point after the withdrawal from the Federation. Demands on schools, hospitals, and infrastructure increased as the population continued to explode, despite reductions in immigration. Relations with other planets were strained and cumbersome to navigate.

The Chariklo Cartel, a renegade group of pirates with no planetary allegiance, saw Ceres as an easy target. The pirates gained full control of the asteroid belt and claimed their new home. They simply eliminated those who did not submit to the pirate code. Ceres is now known as the Pirate Paradise.

17

Epilogue

True to her word, Ceres supported Enceladus when the time came. Ceres sent military forces to the edges of the solar system to battle the Jovian Kingdom.

Earth and Ceres sent scientists to learn more about their energy source. Their militaries occupied Enceladus. They weaponized the molecular hydrogen and began a new arms race.

The other nations never trusted Earth or Ceres again. Any attempts at cooperation ended in political bickering or stalemates. Constant war and conflict plague the entire system to this day.

18

Epilogue

With level-heads, Ceres sent their best diplomats to Enceladus to discuss the occupation of the moon between its leaders and the Queen's government. Through charisma and cunning, they agreed Enceladus would remain neutral and share their power source.

The humans of the solar system enjoyed a post-scarcity lifestyle once energy was no longer a concern. War and overcrowding became things of the past. Peace ruled through the system. Humans looked towards interstellar travel and opened the next chapter in human history.

19

Epilogue

Ceres turned to Earth in their time of need. Through careful negotiations, Earth convinced Mars to cease hostilities. Their cooperation sparked a fresh interest in working together with all humans. When Ceres emerged from isolation, their culture became a curiosity. Cerian entertainment spread like wildfire to the other human settlements.

The Cerian people had developed a peaceful, spiritual lifestyle that became attractive to non-Cerians. Soon the Cerian Way became the predominant religion of the solar system. To this day, Cerian entertainment and religion rule the hearts and minds of all humans.

20

Epilogue

With no allies to help, the fight with Mars was brutal and unforgiving. Mars blocked Ceres from mining vital fuel sources from the asteroid belt, making the Cerian fleet functionally obsolete. Martian warships surrounded Ceres and the armies occupied the dwarf planet. Eventually, Ceres surrendered to Mars.

This was the beginning of the Martian Empire. Mars' ruthlessness and strong will combined with Ceres' resources and technological advances created an unstoppable force. The Empire conquered most human settlements. To this day, Ceres enjoys a slight advantage as the first planet to join the Empire.

21

Epilogue

With proof in hand, Ceres warned the Kingdom of the great threat from Earth. The notice gave them the time needed to prepare for the attack. The Queen was grateful for the information, but history would show that Earth was justified in their plans. The Queen had been planning a three-pronged attack on Earth, Mars, and Ceres. The alliance had lulled Ceres into a false sense of security. They were unprepared for the attack the Queen did eventually execute. Hundreds of thousands of Cerians died as Jovian ships bombarded them. Thousands more would suffer during the occupation. To this day, the people of the Belt are second-class citizens within the Jovian Empire.

22

Epilogue

With proof in hand, a Cerian emissary presented the discovery to Earth's leaders. The hope was to use this leverage to get Ceres one step ahead. However, Earth revealed that the Jovian Kingdom was planning to attack Earth, Mars, and Ceres. Earth's plan was a preemptive strike. Together, the power of all the nations was enough to dissuade the Jovian government from such foolish acts. Despite their difference, the alliance between Earth and Ceres is necessary to keep the Kingdom in check. To this day, the planets of the Sol system remain politically independent but share a common human culture.

23

Epilogue

Earth was fighting a war on all sides. The Terran people tired of the expense and sacrifice demanded by the war with the Jovian Kingdom. Once it ended, there was very little public support for the minor war with Ceres. While much territory swapped hands during the war, the Treaty of Eros returned everything to pre-war conditions. Earth was once a mighty empire as the birthplace of humanity, but other nations grew in power and overshadowed Earth. Ceres became a predominant power in the system as the gateway between the inner and outer planets.

24

Epilogue

The empowered Terran navy made trade within the Jovian Kingdom impossible. They rationed their food, but her environment could not grow enough. Lab-grown sustenance didn't make up the shortfall. The youngest generation of Jovians grew smaller and weaker because of constant malnutrition.

Cerian smugglers and humanitarians joined forces to create a black market on Earth. They paid off officials to turn a blind eye. Cerian crime families made a lucrative business in the Kingdom and controlled much of it through blackmail and bribes. To this day, the underworld runs the outer Solar System and has eyes on the inner planets.

25

Epilogue

The Queen's leadership had been in a decline for years. Her approval ratings were in the single digits. The Jovian subjects tired of those who would not serve the people and only focused on personal power. The Anarchist Revolution not only disposed of political leaders but any person or organization with an unequal amount of wealth or power.

The sentiment quickly spread to Ceres and other planets thereafter. Long-standing institutions were dissolved; religious buildings burned to the ground; businesses collectivized; and communes developed. To this day, everyone is equal in both principal and practice.

26

Epilogue

It took a great deal of strategic planning. Picking just the right junior politicians, arranging convenient accidents or medical emergencies, paying off many people, removing those who would not go along, and regicide. However, within a few cycles, mind-controlled Cerian clones infiltrated the Kingdom's leadership.

The Kingdom became a puppet state controlled by the elite of Ceres. It was used to prop up the Cerian economy, and it fought Ceres' wars all at the expense of the Jovian people. To this day, the Cerian controllers are careful to keep the Jovian people politically and economically divided so they never catch on to who actually runs their planets.

27

Epilogue

Ceres approached Venus, a traditionally neutral power, to act as a mediator. Venus had a lot to gain if she became known as a peace bringer. Through hard negotiations, Earth conceded some of her demands.

Ceres suffered economically after the war, but the agreement left a road for her to grow into a better nation. Ceres worked to rebuild its image with other planets, and after several years, forged a new generation of stronger interplanetary relations. Nowadays, Ceres is the best settlement it has have been since the conflict with Earth.

28

Epilogue

Devastation ruled on Ceres after the war. With no way to expand, her economy became as depressed as her people. The government was in chaos. The entire dwarf planet spiraled out of control while no one helped because it was a tragedy of her own making.

An evil person came to power in Ceres, preying on the weakened people and their festering desire for revenge. He believed the people of Ceres had evolved to be superior humans and had the right to rule over the other humans. To this day, Ceres is engaged in a campaign of rapid, overwhelming forces aimed at total annihilation to conquer other settlements.

29

Epilogue

Ceres knew it would always find itself in the middle of the inner and outer planets, just as a matter of location. So, acting as a peacekeeper, Ceres could create an alliance between the inner and outer planets. Earth and Mars would continue trade and peaceful relations with the Jovian empire, who was free to expand within the outer system. Ceres acted as an arbitrator for any settlement that wished to leave the Kingdom so that the inner planets never had to take sides. An era of peace reigned throughout the solar system.

30

Epilogue

Ceres knew humans would always bicker and fight if not held to strict rules. As a gateway between the inner and outer system, Ceres created a militarized zone out of the Main Belt. Any ships that wanted to move between areas would have to follow Ceres regulations. While trade was stifled at first, merchants became accustomed to Cere's domination through law and order. Ceres controlled both the inner and outer systems with an iron fist for generations to come.

31



O'Neill cylinders are rotating mega structures that provide artificial gravity and an atmosphere. They are placed inside mined asteroids to house people and to create space farms. The cylinders are expensive but are the most Earth-like experience.

Dantu pykrete is a newly discovered material used to build large domes over craters. The area can be paraterraformed to create livable environments so the people can live on the surface of asteroids.

32

Build O'Neill cylinders (33)

"There are constant collisions on the surface. Living inside the asteroid will protect our homes, unlike that ice shield which is totally unproven tech."

Live in giant domes (34)

"We have to invest in new ideas. This new Dantu pykrete can make Ceres the terraforming capital of the solar system. "

Humans continued to mine Ceres to create the space needed and get materials for the cylinder. The Consortium engineered three cylinders: two habitats and one farm. Once completed and tested, the cylinders will be mass produced and built on the asteroids Vesta, Pallas, and Hygiea.



Thermonuclear blasts are expected to bore through to create the start and end points of the final habitat cylinder. The Order of Eternal Darkness has staged a sit-in at the Juling Crater. The Order claims the crater is a holy place and detonating weapons would desecrate its peace.

33

Find an alternative (35)

“Members of the Order are the original inhabitants of this region. To desecrate their land would be dishonorable and violate the original agreement we had with them. We must find another way.”

Nuke the locations (36)

“Those crackpots need to get with the rest of society. Eminent domain exists for a reason. Ignore those Vamps and let’s get on with it.”

Work on the domes brought an economic boom to the settlement. People found work, and it was an attractive place to live. Projections found that the speed of dome construction is not keeping with living space demand.



High radiation levels on the surface permit Ceres laborers to only work in two-hour shifts. This significantly increases the time it takes to build a dome. The Builders Union has suggested increasing the time to four-hour shifts so more work can be done with fewer workers. Happy Workers Inc. has proposed to build three large camps using the 3-D printed Cerstat and shipping in temporary workers from Mars to supplement the jobs.

34

Remove red tape (37)

“Bureaucratic regulations are killing progress and creating delays. Studies have shown four hours of radiation is perfectly safe. Let’s just cut the red tape and get our people to work.”

Build worker housing (38)

“Creating more jobs is the way to go. The Cerstat can house hundreds of people, which will mean around-the-clock shifts and a faster dome.”

They halted the plan to detonate weapons. The Order continues its peaceful ways without interruption. Their extensive observation of the natural water cycles was a great contribution to understanding Ceres. Engineers found an alternative path for the cylinder, but it significantly set production back.



Overcrowding and ship traffic on and around Ceres has led to bickering among members of the Consortium. Major disagreements on how to settle the cylinders cause political upheaval and disruption to mining operations in the Belt.

35

Individual homesteading (39)

“Plenty of people came to Ceres *on their own*, mined the asteroids *on their own*, and survive *on their own*. We deserve independence from the corporations.”

Corporate ownership (40)

“Mining corporations are the backbone of our society. Giving the land to corporations to manage will keep us organized and fruitful.”

Hailed as the start of a new beginning, the four flashes were over in just a few minutes. The nuclear blasts at the craters opened an end-to-end tunnel through Ceres. Construction proceeded without issue. The materials were easily mined from nearby asteroids.



It begins as an innocent tale children tell to scare each other—the Ceres Bigfoot, Dark Crater Yeti, Spacesquatch, and other spectacular entities. However, a science station in the southern region of Pongal Centena releases overwhelming video evidence of an enormous creature resembling a Bigfoot passing the station.

36

Ignore the evidence (41)

“This is all a hoax to get more money for this science station. Their funding is drying up, and they needed to do something ridiculous to get people interested again.”

Explore the evidence (42)

“There is compelling evidence that something beyond our knowledge exists on this planet. It would be irresponsible to throw out data that does not fit our current frame of reference. What if Galileo had done that?”

Ceres needed more domes immediately. The best way to handle that demand was to remove regulations and put building on the fast track. With less oversight, companies took some shortcuts as well. This allowed contractors to build the domes as quickly as the Dantu pykrete cooled.



Twin cities, Datan and Geshtin, are completed and available for habitation around the same time. During a final quality check, an inspector notices stress fractures in minor support beams of Geshtin's dome.

37

Offer a discount (43)

"There's no time to redo all the hard work. Let's offer a low-cost option for the less fortunate that will cover our costs. If something happens, they won't have the power to do anything."

Fix the problems (44)

"We are talking about real human lives we are gambling. We must, at any cost, repair the damage to Geshtin and make sure it is as safe as Datan."

They built hundreds of Cerstats camps on the surface. Crime in Ceres increased with hate crimes against the temporary workers. They are seen as foreigners stealing Cerian jobs. Social unrest is rampant while the domes proceeded at record speed.



A coronal mass ejection on the sun's surface causes a massive X-class solar flare. When it reaches Ceres, everyone inside a Cerstat loses consciousness. The event is referred to as the X-flare Eruption. Affected people appear to have extrasensory perception, and are called Sensitives.

38

Integrate Sensitives (45)

"We should use these Sensitives. By letting them join the police force, we can read guilty people's minds. In a hospital, they can predict the cure before there is a diagnosis."

Segregate Sensitives (46)

"We have no way of controlling these Martians if they can read our minds. They can destroy all our hard work by exposing everything. We can't risk sending them home. Separate them for the safety of our agenda."

New Venice was the first Cerian cylinder settlement. Individuals from all walks of life, including engineers, scientists, laborers, clergy, and merchants migrated there. New Venice became a model for a self-sustaining, equitable community.



Capitolium Aeronautics is the company responsible for the Legionary, a highly automated collision monitoring system. Calculations show New Venice may be in the direct path of an oncoming asteroid. Suddenly, communications with the defense systems have gone haywire and Capitolium suspects hackers have sabotaged it.

39

Wait it out (47)

“We cannot abandon all the work New Venice has done. It is the first successful, peaceful human settlement in the Belt. Capitolium has plenty of time to fix their supposed communication issues and destroy those asteroids.”

Abandon the site (48)

“Do we want to risk the lives of hundreds of Ceres citizens on an ideal? We can repair the cylinder, but we cannot replace those lost lives. We must abandon the site and move the people until it is safe.”

Legislation allowed corporations to develop a fair housing plan in exchange for large plots of land. Dozens of corporations built their version of the ideal settlement. As profits rolled in from subdividing the land, the corporations built their own cylinders in nearby asteroids.



The Platinum Group Collective, a group of rogue settlers, manufactured their own cylinder with stolen plans. Corporations are suing to seek their removal, claiming they are illegally occupying the land and stealing patented proprietary technology.

40

 Use force to remove (49)

“We cannot allow just anyone to build these cylinders. Decades of hard work and money went into securing our private property. Allowing these unlicensed, unregulated groups can mean untold harm.”

 Allow to remain (50)

“We all came to Ceres being promised a better life. For some, that means taking life by the reins and creating your own pathway to success. We should celebrate these mavericks for their ingenuity and resourcefulness.”

Dismissed as data from faulty equipment, the public relegated the Yeti to the realm of folklore and legends. The cylinder construction was an overwhelming success. The Ceres Consortium sends self-replicating, AI-driven robots throughout the Belt to collect materials, manufacture parts, and build more cylinders.



Overnight, the Vesta cohort of robots ceased working. Diagnostics at the Ceres home base show they are still powered on and report no errors. Suddenly, the entire cohort is heading for Ceres like a swarm of space bees.

41

Destroy the robots (51)

"This is it.. the great robot uprising. We need to obliterate those bots NOW."

Monitor the situation (52)

"Don't be ridiculous. Even if there was some sentience to those robots, the first rule is that they cannot harm humans."

Upon closer examination, scientists discovered the evidence reveals a significant Mach effect at the appearance and disappearance of the creature. They create more research stations to find and record other instances.



Through unprecedented cross-disciplinary cooperation, the scientific community can state that multiple dimensions exist. In fact, doorways between the dimensions are opening at regular intervals on Ceres and can be used for exploration. This is where the interdimensional creature dubbed the Spacesquatch comes from.

42

Military mission (53)

"We need to contain this information as soon as possible. If other planets get wind of it, they will look to invade us. We must cover it up and begin a military exploration of the other dimensions."

Scientific exploration (54)

"This is a discovery of the lifetime and belongs to all humans. We need to publish these findings so that scientists of all nations can review and offer their support. We should begin scientific exploration with a civilian corp."

Marketers sold the Geshtin dome as an affordable way to live in luxury housing. Builders and architects insisted they made everything with the same materials, but residents noticed some stark differences between the two domes. Most people remained quiet because they were happy to have a permanent home.



At approximately 1540 Ceres standard time, Geshtin residents hear a loud snap, but dismiss it as a dust storm. At 1550, the first alarms sound as cracks appear in the protective glass. By 1600, the dome is collapsing, and residents unable to reach protective gear suffocate to death.

43

Reveal the cause (55)

“The people deserve to know what happened. Let’s tell them all about the cuts we made to get done in time. We must hold the guilty accountable.”

Bury the truth (56)

“That’s ridiculous! No one will ever trust construction company and material corporations again. We have to protect the companies.”

The dome was repaired, but the people's trust with anyone involved was not. Like-minded people organized into gangs and militia, intent on keeping an eye on those in power and preventing their people from being taken advantage of. Tribalism was strong on Ceres.



The Coppers, a ruthless gang of Geshtin domers, took hostage the board members of a prestigious holding company, accusing them of being part of a large conspiracy to control everything. The Coppers released a list of names they believe are part of the cabal. They demand arrests and military tribunals.

44

Pay off the gang (57)

"While not wrong, their conspiracy theories seem too far-fetched for anyone to believe. Let's simply pay off this gang so that they quietly go away and everyone will forget this incident."

Send in mercenaries (58)

"We cannot negotiate with domestic terrorists. Let's send in some of our elite forces to quickly take care of this matter and stop anyone from having similar aspirations."

Top psychologists develop the Vernon-Carr test for the extrasensory potential of individuals. Using this test, officials assign Sensitives a rank based on their ability. Job opportunities for those ranked highly are plenty and employers seek those with a proven V-C rating.



Law enforcement arrests Rowan Castillo, a well-known mid-grade mobster, on charges of falsified V-C papers. He attempted to get a job with a politician when they discovered the discrepancy. Initial investigations lead law enforcement to believe there is something deeper to the story than just forgery.

45

Investigate further (59)

“We aren’t in control of this. We need to dig to the bottom of this and root out anyone involved. This kind of thing doesn’t happen just once.”

Let him take the fall (60)

“Castillo will be happy to take the fall to protect the family. There’s no need to look any further at what is a small-time crime.”

Officials relegate Sensitives to second-class citizens. They cannot own businesses or work in certain professions. Propaganda and fear-mongering further propel hatred and distrust among the average citizen.



The medical community detects an illness among the Sensitive. Without treatment or a cure, the disease appears to be extremely deadly. No one is certain how it is being contracted. Camilla Delgado, a popular and well-respected Sensitive musician, announces she has the disease. Three days later, she dies.

46

Address the illness (61)

“We can’t afford an epidemic. We need to put extra money and research into finding how it is contracted and how we can stop it.”

Turn them away (62)

“This is just a ploy by Sensitives to get handouts from the government. A normal human can’t even get the disease. Why should we waste money on something that’s a problem in an isolated community?”

Epilogue

Miraculously, Capitolium Aeronautics diverted the asteroids at the last minute, saving the entire population of New Venice. Proven a success, the Consortium built other cylinders on asteroids in the belt. They were all modeled after New Venice, a self-sufficient, peaceful, and equitable community.

The Belt has seen very little internal conflict since every community could care for itself. To this day, Cerians enjoy a long life because of a clean environment and stress-free life.

47

Epilogue

Most New Venice dwellers packed up their bags and headed back to their ships. Some scientists refused to leave experiments that required the surface. Sadly, Capitolium Aeronautics could never regain full control of the anti-collision systems. The asteroids hit close enough that all of New Venice was lost. Capitolium paid to repair the cylinder and reestablish the environment.

Capitalistic corporations run settlements on Ceres. Those with the most money have the best living situation. Those who do not are relegated to government-run ghettos on colony ships. To this day, those with power and money excel on Ceres.

48

Epilogue

The occupation of the Platinum Group Cylinder ended after a 51-day standoff with authorities. Injuries and deaths occurred on both sides. The fledgling buildings ignited in flames after the capture of the town's mayor and religious leader, Adam Gorgesh, destroying the entire community. Since that day, only licensed corporations could build cylinders in the Belt.

Corporations have a land monopoly. Individuals on Ceres must become loyal to a megacorp in order to live. They go to megacorp-run schools, shop at megacorp stores, and sleep in megacorp homes they rent.

49

Epilogue

The Platinum Group Collective was allowed to remain. Other groups of people, able to gather the resources and technology, could also build new habitats. Some were gated corporate communities of the ultra-wealthy, others were cobbled together communities of low-wage workers and indentured servants. High-tech meccas of cargo containers where citizens enjoy a virtual world or strict religious communes formed.

The people were free to choose the community that best fits them. To this day, while it is not always equitable, at least the people of the Belt are only beholden to their chosen community.

50

Epilogue

A multitude of missiles was sent to destroy the robots. Ceres defensive ships cleaned up any stragglers. Once scientists recovered the remains of the robots, they found each one had its core operating system reprogrammed. It was unclear the purpose of their approach, but the swift action may have saved all of Ceres if the robots were planning to attack. Conspiracy theorists believe that they had gained sentience and were coming to overthrow their human creators. To this day, many people in the Belt will not trust robots and insist on using humans for labor.

51

Epilogue

The robots approached Ceres and sent out a simple communication, "More power." It was difficult to understand the meaning behind the message. Many saw it as an aggressive move. However, in time, the people of Ceres would learn the robots were simply asking to be paid for their labor. One robot had gained sentience and spread its programming to the others, but without a stronger energy source they could not muster enough computing power to grow in intelligence. AI has come a long way since its birth in the Belt. To this day, humans and artificial life work and live side-by-side.

52

Epilogue

Armed with the greatest military tech that Ceres could develop, the soldiers stepped into the doorway under the cloak of nighttime. Monitoring from Mission Control, those back on Ceres had an uninterrupted view via cameras and sensors of what the team experienced. The soldier's orders were to shoot first and ask questions later.

The soldiers encountered a world filled with creatures identical to the Spacesquatch. A misunderstanding led to a shoot out that left every soldier dead. Any further attempts to cross the barrier end in violence as the creatures refuse entry into their world.

53

Epilogue

A team of humanity's greatest scientists set out to explore the great unknown. Using the interdimensional doorways, they stepped into a new plane of existence. Their helmets recorded everything. The broadcast was live-streamed to billions of humans.

The scientists encountered a Ceres filled with intelligent Spacesquatches. This version of Ceres had fully formed into a planet and had an indigenous species that evolved with superior intelligence. Scientists, politicians, and citizens alike worked with the Spacesquatches. To this day, anyone can travel to the other side with the proper traveling visa and enjoy the wonders of a whole different universe.

54

Epilogue

Everyone knew they cut corners when building the Geshtin dome. The residents had complained for years, but no one would listen to those with so little. Reporters exposed the truth. After the Great Collapse, the rest of Ceres realized that those in power had sacrificed the lives of those they considered lesser.

A revolution occurred after the Great Collapse. Corrupt unions, organized crime, and immoral corporations were all rooted out and destroyed. Society was careful to put steps in place to ensure the balance of power and to avoid corruption. To this day, Ceres is one of the most fairest and equitable places to live.

55

Epilogue

A sham commission blamed the Great Collapse on a shell construction company. That company went bankrupt, and no one was ever found criminally negligent. Cerians continued to live on colony ships because few, except the very wealthy, would trust dome construction.

The Great Collapse sent the settling of Ceres back decades. A new method of building underground cities became popular but was far from the Earth-like experience humans were used to. People had to emigrate back to their home planet or move further out to the solar system because there were no suitable places to live in the Belt.

56

Epilogue

They say everyone has their price and even the Coppers did. With their pockets full of untraceable cash, they abandoned their plans and were unheard of for some time. But the payoff was exactly the seed money that they needed to jump-start their domestic terrorist activities. Once well funded and organized, the Coppers systematically took down the establishment. They bought out companies, murdered key individuals, and engaged in the mass destruction of institutions. Thousands died in their attacks. This led to a widespread destabilization of Ceres society. The asteroids of the Belt devolved into pure chaos and became a dangerous place to be.

57

Epilogue

The Chrono Corporation was hired to take care of the problem. They forced their way into the building and hit everyone with a new chemical weapon. Rizonanium contained nanobot technology that could influence the exposed's thoughts and emotions. The hostages were safe, but it didn't stop there. The Rizonanium became viral and went on to infect most of the population. With ultimate control, the Chrono Corporation shaped Ceres. The CEO's vision was a Belt where the rich got richer and the poor stayed poor. Ceres became a play land for the wealthy and influential, while the general masses toiled away for their benefit and were too dumb or unemotional to realize how bad they had it.

58

Epilogue

Levdrom reporters uncover a large-scale ring of fraud and abuse. The Castillo Crime family was falsifying records and blackmailing or paying off Sensitives to do their bidding. They infiltrated every avenue of society: government, law, health, even entertainment. There's no telling how much control they would have if left to their devices.

Breaking the ring freed many Sensitives and enabled better policies to eliminate fraud. Ceres was the only settlement that had Sensitives helping. With good people in the right places, society could prosper. Corruption and greed became a thing of the past.

59

Epilogue

The court punished Rowan, but he only served a portion of his sentence. He was back at the top of society in no time. His entire crime family enjoyed great luck and rose to the top of society. They created a network of conspirators, paid-off members of the government, and blackmailed individuals to get anything that they wanted. They had a firm grip over most Sensitives on the planet and could get rid of any that did not comply.

Ceres became a different place once ruled by a single mob family. It became a haven for all criminal and immoral behavior. It became known for gambling, arms deals, art theft, and hitmen.

60

Epilogue

Entertainers organized benefit concerts and special events to raise money to research the illness. Health agencies mobilized to contain it and assist those in need. Corporations invested in research to find a cure.

Better research shows that the illness, while initially isolated to Sensitive communities, was spreading to the population at large. Researchers discovered a cure and stop the disease in its tracks.

It took time, but eventually the Sensitives found acceptance in society. Their work in hospitals, police forces, courts of law, and social work has had a profound effect on Ceres, making it a much more empathetic and caring society.

61

Epilogue

No one helped the Sensitive community. Because they have no established doctors or medical funding, they made little headway against the disease. Cases popped up among the “normal” Ceres population, showing that all humans were susceptible to it. The disease spreads like wildfire. The death toll was catastrophic.

Some fled on so-called Plague Ships. Other planets prohibit anyone from the Asteroid Belt from entering their space. Most ships are destroyed or the inhabitants are left to slowly die from lack of resources.

Survivors on the asteroids tried to make the most of life, but a post-apocalyptic lifestyle is challenging at best.

62



Mining is the lifeblood of everyone on Ceres, whether they came here as independent miners, as part of a company expedition, or for lucrative jobs in the service industry for those miners. Economists suggest Ceres will benefit from a regulated market where the Consortium sets prices and rules for mining and trade. However, many influential corporations insist that a free market without interference from the Consortium will mean more wealth for Ceres.

63

Regulated market (64)

“Regulations will ensure proper oversight, which means safety, anti-discrimination, and environmental protection. It will make for a more equal and fair Ceres.”

Free Market (65)

“A centralized system that sets our regulations and prices will stifle innovation and investment. Only a free market will let Ceres prosper.”

The Organization of Main Belt Resources Miners (OMBRM) was created to stabilize the mining resource markets, secure a steady income to miners, and guarantee a fair return on investment for companies. Other planets complain they are just a powerful anti-competitive cartel.



Comms Officer Mildred McGrath stationed on the 44 Nysa Customs Station hears the distinctive sound of a repeated message through the open channel. It comes from an unidentified source and sounds very alien to her. After verifying that it is more than background noise, she alerts the Consortium. They confirm it is a deliberate message.

64

Crowdsource discovery (66)

“We should crowd source this discovery. Put it out to every scientist, linguist, and cryptologist to figure it out.”

Send ship (67)

“Other people are going to discover this signal with or without us. Let’s get the jump on them and send out a ship now to intercept whatever it is sending it.”

The Consortium voted to allow a free market to reign throughout the Belt. Corporations jumped at the chance to invest in mining expeditions to thousands of open asteroids. Competition brought living wages and beneficial working conditions for the laborers.



While opening a new mine on resource-rich 65 Cybele, geologists discover a strange series of tunnels. The mining company's lead scientist insists they are a natural occurrence from ice melting. Independent researchers who received leaked documents believe there is evidence of a living organism.

65

 Look for organism (68)

"This organism can be an amazing scientific discovery that can bring us fame and fortune. We can afford to make some sacrifices to find it."

 Cover up the leak (69)

"We already have water shortages and Cybele is a vital source. We must silence this leak and continue operations. We need the water."

News of the signal hit all the popular networks and created an initial wave of interest throughout the Belt. Everyone had their own theory about what it meant. The message was extremely degraded but its repetitive nature lead to great speculation that it was a distress signal.



Space Vertex is a corporation run by Gunther Vang, a billionaire futurist. His research shows that the message came from a spacecraft on the edge of the solar system. He owns a one-man spacecraft, the Sturgeon, that could go farther than any other vehicle. Vang offers to pilot it himself, since communication with the alien ship is not possible.

66

Let Vang go (70)

“Vang knows the ship best and gives Ceres the greatest chance for a successful mission to the solar system’s edge.”

Replace Vang (71)

“Vang is an unknown entity. We’ve never been able to buy him or get him under our thumbs. We need to seize that vehicle and send one of our own in his place.”

To keep public speculation down and to better study the signal, the Consortium kept the discovery hidden. Instead, they sent three secret ships on a multi-year mission to the outer regions of the solar system to discover the source.



The ships return with a derelict cigar-shaped alien vessel. They hide the vessel inside 221 Eos and study it in a secret lab. While there are minimal power readings coming from the ship, sensors indicate there is a life form aboard. They crack the ship open and find a single human frozen inside a cryochamber, about two meters tall with long blond hair and blue eyes.

67

Study the subject (72)

“We don’t know anything about that human. We need to keep it on ice and on the Eos Research station where it won’t be a threat.”

Awake the human (73)

“There has to be some logical explanation to why we found a human inside an alien ship. Perhaps if we wake them, we can find out more.”

Digging deeper, scientists found a unique species of tardigrade never seen before. These cute fuzzy creatures were significantly larger than the Earth version, measuring around 50 cm each. They live in a complex underground cave system hundreds of meters inside the asteroids.



Human activity on the asteroid is changing the tardigrade habitat and causing them to die off in mass numbers. Dr. Fatima Moussa estimates that since humans began mining, nearly 75% of the tardigrade population has died off.

68

Move to a zoo (74)

“With dwindling number, we need to take dramatic action. A zoo will help us preserve the biodiversity and potentially conserve the creature while we learn more.”

Protect their home (75)

“These tardigrades have every right to this asteroid, more than we do. We should protect their natural habitat and stop all mining activity here.”

The Cybele mine operated successfully for several years. It produced significant amounts of nickel and iron used within the transportation industry in their maglev systems. The last explorative shaft of the mine led to disappointment when they discovered no more mineral veins. They officially abandoned the mine.



Timur Cetin was spelunking in an abandoned mine on 298 Baptistina, found a metallic block with strange alien writing, and brought the artifact to the Ceres Museum. They discover it's made of solar-powered material that charges it with energy. The linguistics AI interprets the script to include the words "diaspora" and "collision".

69

Power up (76)

"We were meant to discover this artifact. If we can power this thing up, let's do it. Find out who left it and why."

Take apart (77)

"We really shouldn't be activating some kind of ancient alien tech without taking a few precautions. Let's take it apart first and see what makes it tick."

On the Sturgeon, Vang studied the ship with all available sensors. The signal continued to broadcast, but its meaning eluded scientists. As the Sturgeon approached the alien ship, its camera feed shows a blinding blue light before all signals from the Sturgeon go dead.



Back on Ceres, sensors show the alien ship is moving through the system. It pauses briefly at Europa before continuing towards the Belt. People are on edge as no one can determine the meaning of its slow approach.

70

Allow to approach (78)

“Perhaps they captured the Sturgeon to understand us and are now coming to return Vang. We should let them come to us and see what they want.”

Send out ships (79)

“We have corporate ships that can go out and meet them. If there’s going to be trouble, let it be in outside our space.”

Right before he would have taken off, agents kidnapped Vang and replaced him with a look-alike. The Sturgeon contacted the alien ship. It welcomed the pilot on board. After three days, the pilot informed the Consortium that he was bringing the aliens to Ceres for diplomatic talks.



At the end of the official discussions, it's announced that a diplomatic crew of the Grays, an alien race from the Zeta Reticuli system, will stay on Ceres. Gray historians reveal that they previously had a treaty with humans when they were still on Earth. They hope to continue that positive relationship.

71

Work with the aliens (80)

"Technically, we already have a treaty with them. These aliens mean us no harm. Let's work with them for the benefit of the entire human race."

Keep tabs on the aliens (81)

"We shouldn't be trusting these guys. Sure, they didn't blow up our planet. But is that really the low bar for establishing diplomatic ties?"

Agents took the cryochamber to a top-secret lab deep in the Ceres underground. Only those with the highest security clearance could study it. DNA showed that the being is 98% human, but there is a fair amount of foreign DNA.



Dr. Sophie Fernandez, a renowned project biologist, makes a secret deal with the Medi-News holo-network to reveal the truth behind the frozen body found on the ship. She believes the creature is a human-alien hybrid the aliens created through human experiments.

72

Block the story (82)

“Look, this lady is just going to cause a bunch of anti-alien sentiment by throwing out these crazy theories about human abduction and experiments. We need to quash this story before it happens.”

Broadcast the story (83)

“If she has the scientific evidence to back up her claims, we should let her speak. If what she says is true, we need to consider what our relationship with an alien race would be, anyway.”

After a brief period to ensure they can safely do it, scientists thawed and woke up the person inside. His name is Hunqeall Braugrurs Yuveat, a member of an alien race from the Pleiades. Yuveat stated that the Pleiadians and Humans are a related species having come from the same source of cosmic life billions of years ago.



Three large flying saucer-shaped ships orbit Ceres. Yuveat explains they are the Zeta Reticulians. They attacked the ship on-route to the Sol system and killed the rest of the shipmates. Yuveat survived by entering the cryochamber. The aliens in the saucers demand that Mars turn Yuveat over to them because he's a fugitive.

73

Try to meet aliens first (84)

"This is our chance to be intergalactic diplomatic superstars. Let's meet with the Zeta Reticulians and try to find a peaceful solution to this."

Give over Yuveat (85)

"We don't need those flying saucers throwing lasers at our planet. Let's just hand this alien over and maybe we can figure things out afterward."

Biologists collected Cybele tardigrades and built a zoo. The Tardigrades failed to prosper in captivity and died off. A few specimens were flash-dried hoping future generations of scientists can determine why they could not live in captivity. Cybele tardigrades become extinct.



Asteroid miners spend more time on the surface than ever before because of advances in robotics. The lack of an atmosphere means they need to wear anti-radiation gear. Dr. Madalitso Rossi of the Ceres Health Institute has speculated that studying the radiation resistances of the remaining tardigrade could yield positive results.

74

Use the last specimen (86)

“There’s no reason to keep something sitting on ice if it can be used to our benefit. Studying the DNA of those creatures will be worth it, even if it destroys them.”

Find an alternative (87)

“We took these tardigrades from their environment and nearly destroyed them. If we have it in our power to bring them back, we should do that.”

Legislation barred any mining on asteroids where potential life has been detected. Baptistina became a tourist attraction as people of all ages come to see the “real aliens” in their natural habitat. The holo-vid networks set up live streaming so people can watch from home.

An avid water bear watcher, Heather “Toots” Bartoszek, notices an odd repetitive behavior by the tardigrades. She begins her own VueTube channel claiming the tardigrades are communicating with her. Most believe it’s a joke, but the channel continues to gain popularity and the footage is being viewed throughout the Belt.

75

Support holo-vid (88)

“This could be just the hook we need. Original intelligent life on our asteroids! We should scream this from our ships. We need around-the-clock coverage to everyone!”

Perform scientific study (89)

“If there’s any credence to this story, we need to study it. We cannot do that with all of those eyes watching. Let’s cut the cameras and do some genuine science here, people.”

On top of Ahuna Mon, reflective mirrors drove sunlight into it. The object came to life. A holographic projection explained that 80 million years ago the inhabitants of the planet Llashu faced extinction. Their only option was to create this artifact and bury it deep within the surface in hopes someone would find it.



Through interactions with the device, scientists gather information. The artifact is a high-capacity storage device. Ancient Llashuns had spent their remaining time devising a method for transferring their consciousness into a digital format. The device contains the last remains of the ancient civilization, but they can be brought back to life. **76**

Research import tech (90)

“This is the answer to eternal life. Figure out how they did it, then we can add a few test subjects into the device. Once we learn everything is safe, we can start transferring humans.”

Research export tech (91)

“Putting one of the supposed aliens into a physical body so we can interrogate them will tell us if this is real or if they are all just ghosts in the machine. We need to know this first.”

Technicians placed the artifact in a secure research facility on 221 Eos. Intelligence officers determine from the writing that billions of years ago intelligent creatures lived, but an asteroid killed off the population and destroyed the planet. It becomes a closely guarded secret.



A careful dissection of the device reveals it is a storage unit for vast amounts of digital data. It has a physical projection system on the outside that was destroyed during the investigation. The technology is well beyond anything the Consortium scientists can fully grasp. Dr. Erik Slora suggests he can plug the device into his experimental neural link as a last-ditch effort.

77

Archive the data (92)

“Using experimental methods on alien technology is too dangerous. Let’s download the data we have onto our systems and let the digital archivists pick it apart.”

Use neural link (93)

“We should use every method at our disposal. The doctor assures us that the neural link will gives us the most accurate access to the data.”

Epilogue

The alien vessel landed on Ceres without objection. Vang served as an envoy between the humans and the Zeta Reticulians, commonly referred to as the Grays. He revealed he is a human/alien hybrid placed on Ceres and tasked with preparing humans for their arrival. He was successful in establishing peace between the Grays and humans.

An immigration program was established. Cerians were the first humans to live on Zeta Reticuli I. Entire communities of Grays opted to move to Ceres as well. To this day, there are challenges, but the cooperation between the two races leads to prosperity.

78

Epilogue

Ceres asked volunteer ships and crews to form a fleet to approach the ship. The vessel from Dynamo Corps overreacted when the alien ship made a sudden trajectory change.

The aggression led to a catastrophic end to alien relations in the galaxy. Hostile actions killed all three Gray aliens on board, but they had enough time to send a warning light-years away to the Galactic Alliance.

To this day, humans are engaged in constant wars with the Alliance. The distance between the civilizations prohibits either side from winning, so there is no end in sight for the conflict.

79

Epilogue

The Grays hadn't always planned to take over Ceres. After seeing the struggles of humanity, they felt it was the moral choice to guide their development. It started on Ceres, but the Grays continued to gain control over the entire human race. They infiltrated every level of government and society with the help of human collaborators.

The Gray overlords were generally kind. They ensured humans had proper housing and subsistence. They even instituted breeding programs to ensure the proper continuation of the race. To this day, humans try to gain freedom, but the Grays are quick to root out and destroy any rebellion.

80

Epilogue

Closely watching the government and the Gray diplomatic corps, certain discrepancies were noticed. Humans were a crafty and resilient race. Over time, evidence was gathered in secret to prove that certain Consortium officials had been replaced by human-alien hybrid doppelgangers. The Great Reveal caused disruption through the solar system. Humans managed to systematically eliminate or imprison all the hybrids. Collaborates were tried and executed for treason. Humans had regained control of their society.

To this day, a retaliatory fleet is on its way to the Zeta Reticulai system using acquired technology from the Grays. Only time will tell if humans will have revenge.

81

Epilogue

The broadcast was eliminated. When scientists attempted to thaw the body, they discovered that it had spent too long in the chamber. It never recovered.

An autopsy revealed it was not an alien-human hybrid, but a species of alien that was a distant relative of humans (which is why they shared so much DNA).

Ceres tried to use his ship to contact other aliens. However, all attempts went unanswered. The Galactic Alliance was monitoring the Sol system and was outraged by humanity's barbarism. The Council decided humanity would need another few centuries to evolve before they could possibly receive contact.

82

Epilogue

The broadcast had the single most viewership of any holo-network. Unfortunately, the signals reached more than just the Belt. Thousands of light years away, the Galactic Alliance also heard the broadcast and discovered where the criminal Hunqeall Braugrurs Yuveat was hiding. They immediately sent three Zeta Reticulians ships to retrieve Yuveat and to wipe the memory of all humans.

The Galactic Alliance sets up beacons around the Sol system to warn away other intelligent space faring races. They label it as a dangerous quarantine zone to ensure that no one will be visiting these planets any time in the future.

83

Epilogue

Ceres sent a message to the saucers and arranged a meeting. A diplomatic group of four Zeta Reticulians takes part in negotiations. Martians learned that Yuveat and shipmates were a group of rogue Pleiadians who believed they should give humanity a second chance. However, the Galactic Alliance barred contact with humans until their obsession with nuclear weapons ended. Yuveat wants to guide humans into an era of peace and asks Ceres for sanctuary.

The Cerians grant Yuveat's request. Unfortunately, humanity's deep-seated distrust for alien races prohibits them from learning any lessons Yuveat shares. The Galactic Alliance was right.

84

Epilogue

The Cerians agreed to turn over Yuveat to the other alien vessels without trying to negotiate. One ship remains behind. A group of short gray aliens with large heads and long, thin fingers exit the ship.

They are from the Zeta Reticuli star system and had visited humans before. They agreed to stay on Ceres and shared their advanced technology (as they had in the past) as a sign of their good intentions.

Unfortunately, Ceres was not aware that the Grays wanted better access to kidnap humans. Back on Zeta Reticuli II, humans are used for slave labor. A virus caused them to nearly become extinct and the Grays needed more stock for breeding and experimentation.

85

Epilogue

The Ceres Health Institute (CHI) decoded the tardigrades DNA and determined the source of their resistance to radiation. Through CRISPR technology, CHI can free miners of their protective gear to work on the surface. What few knew is that CHI already had the tech through illegal human trials, but they used the specimen as cover. They destroyed all remaining samples to cover their tracks. While studying the remains, Shila Munsie, a microbiologist, discovered a more complex brain structure than previously thought, a sign that the tardigrades had the capacity for language and social learning. Cerians were ashamed to learn that they wiped out native intelligent life.

86

Epilogue

Advocates for the tardigrades pushed back and made it unconscionable to use the last of the specimens just for the convenience of humanity. Theo Bailey, a graduate student at the University of Columbia Hills, studied the abandoned habitats and discovered signs of complex social structures. Further study showed that they were highly intelligent life forms that could communicate. Biologists recovered DNA from the last remaining specimen to bring them back. Limits on cloning technology meant the living tardigrades were not as intelligent as their predecessors. To this day, anyone can visit Tardigrade Park and see the original Belt aliens.

87

Epilogue

It eventually became clear that the tardigrades were communicating. The first breakthrough came when a tardigrade gave a simple command and the humans retrieved an item they asked for.

The tardigrades saw this as the perfect opportunity. They were a symbiotic creature that controlled the minds of their host. During a board meeting, their leaders integrated with Sunshine Studios executives. To this day, the tardigrades secretly control the dreams and desires of humanity through the entertainment industry.

88

Epilogue

At midnight, all public cameras feeds from the habitats stopped broadcasting. The area was turned into a research station. Scientists stayed behind their closed doors, but some information leaked out.

The tardigrades were highly intelligent creatures. Their central appendage made it possible to bond with humans and take control of their minds. They were not happy with being treated as a science experiment.

During the Night of Silence, tardigrades forcefully took control of the scientists. Systematically, the tardigrades infiltrated the Cerian humans until none were left untouched. To this day, Ceres is run by tardigrades in human host bodies.

89

Epilogue

The Ceres Consortium invested in a research facility specifically to study the ancient device. Once the device was fully powered, the Llashun neuroscientist and computer engineers described the process and transferred the how-to knowledge to humans. Given time, the Ceres scientists developed a way to transfer a human consciousness.

To this day, theologians still debate whether the humans in the Titan Storage Base are still the same people they were in their physical bodies. But for those who can afford it, they see it as a chance at eternal life.

90

Epilogue

A group of the largest mining companies came together to fund the research into developing physical bodies for the Llashuns. Through experimentation, researchers developed a biological 3D printed body that mimicked the Llashuns original bodies. A Llashun was only permitted to occupy the patented technology after an agreement where they would work manual labor for a number of cycles before granted their freedom from the corporations. To this day, the only way to own a Retro-Skin is to enter into indentured servitude and work the mines. The program does offer perks such as great insurance if the skin is damaged at the workplace and ten free backups each year.

91

Epilogue

Investigators created a 500-page report on the findings of the artifact, marked it as top secret, and placed both in a box on a shelf in a warehouse. Over two centuries later, a kid discovered the box after it had been disposed of in a trash heap. The device was intact, but the report was long gone. She plugged it into her VR set, mistaking it for a common VR world pack. She entered a strange world of alien beings who claimed to come from a now-destroyed planet. She found the game boring and never turned it back on.

To this day, Ishi Bowman will never know that the digital remains of an entire billion-year-old alien race lay dormant on her desk.

92

Epilogue

Dr. Slora's neural link established a connection with the device. He navigated the system for hours before returning to the present world to report his findings. He explained the device contained historic records of a now-extinct intelligent race that existed billions of years ago. It took him years to extract the data which is now available at the Llashun Memorial and Research Center.

What he didn't tell them was that the records were the memories of all the digital lives in the device. The Llashun people had downloaded their consciousness onto the device. The egotistical and pathological Dr. Slora kept them in his own private, virtual playground to do with what he pleased.

93



The original agreement that created the Ceres Consortium is set to expire. The colonists of the Asteroid Belt must decide how to form their government. Some believe that Earth has excellent models to build from, while others argue they have all been disasters.

94

Try something new (95)

"If Earth was such a perfect example, we would all still be there. We need to get creative and invent something new."

Model on Earth (96)

"You don't get perfection by throwing everything out; you need to make small, incremental changes. Pick something we used and improve it."

Debates on a new form of government continue long after a decision should have been made. A consensus cannot be reached. The power structure created temporarily is looking more permanent as each cycle passes.



As the months draw on without a decision, some members argue that no government is better than a broken one. Others believe technology can be the answer they've been seeking.

95

 No one should rule (97)

"All these so-called social contracts do the same thing: they limit individual freedoms."

 Use technology (98)

"Humans are flawed and so is our way of thinking. Entrusting technology is the best way to lead to fairness."

A consensus is reached that modeling the government on Earth policies is the best way to guide this infant state. A congress representing various interests of the people is established with delegates from all around the Asteroid Belt.



The elitists push for the government to restrict who can be in power, while others believe Ceres should be a place where having larger numbers lead will be more successful.

96

 Few should rule (99)

“The ignorant masses will only lead us to destruction. We should empower the few who can lead us to a stronger future.”

 Many should rule (100)

“One of the strengths of Ceres is our diversity. We need to lean into that and allow for many voices that will lead to sound decisions.”

Discussions are underway on how Ceres could exist as a free state. Most have come to agree that there is to be no coercive rule by any one single group or individual. However, anarchy is so radically different from the systems everyone left that arguments break out about all the small details.



Lerin Hill grew up in a community that valued cooperation over hierarchy. She has an uncanny ability to form logical conclusions that lead to compromise. Everyone turns to her first when a difficult or contentious topic arises. Much progress has been made under her guidance.

97

Muscle for power (101)

“Anyone that comfortable with compromise can be lured over to our way and corrupted by the promise of power. She can be our puppet, and we can rule Ceres.”

Support a free state (102)

“Putting all our eggs in one basket makes for possible ruin. Supporting a free state means we can possibly control hundreds of people.”

A summit of the brightest technologists of Ceres gathers to produce options for using technology to help govern the people. The nightmares of failed Earth politics plague the Belters, and most have lost faith in humans being able to govern themselves. The summit concludes that artificial intelligence is the answer.



Computer scientists have come up with two potential options. Given the proper parameters and training, a highly intelligent AI could be instated as a sole ruler. Or the AI could choose humans placed into compulsory service from a lottery.

98

Institute AI ruler (103)

“Our world is rapidly evolving. Only AI can keep up with that and make logical decisions that won’t discriminate.”

Create lottery (104)

“Anyone who wants to be in politics, probably shouldn’t. By having technology choose random individuals, we will have a representative government and put an end to career politicians.”

Congress finishes its last session before their scheduled break with an agreement that a select few must run the government. The founding principle is that not everyone is equipped with the skills to make the required tough decisions. Only those with the ability to do so should.



Once congress reconvenes, two factions gather the majority of support. The scientists argue that politics was responsible for too many decisions and that is why Earth has started to crumble. Others argue that the people of Earth simply lost faith in a core belief and that is what led to the downfall of the planet.

99

Support scientists (105)

"We need to use scientific facts to rule our people. Evidence-based policy is the only way to safely move forward on Ceres to ensure we can survive."

Support faith (106)

"A government founded on a common belief will lead to stability. We need that in this dangerous place. We need to know we can depend on one another."

“Power to the people” becomes the Ceres slogan for some time. The decision is made to entrust the future of the planet to everyone. A grassroots organization starts a guerilla marketing campaign to encourage the public to engage in the process. Everyone gets behind the idea.



A complex system of public referendums, local decision-making, and digital democracy sets Ceres on a slow track of governance. Eventually, the fervor dies down. Belters get back to their real lives, and they find they don't have time to pay attention to governing.

100

Appoint representatives (107)

“Look, nobody’s got time for this. We’re busy just trying to survive out here. Let’s appoint who we think will make good decisions and move on from this nonsense.”

Simplify system (108)

“Direct democracy is working; our system is just way too complex. We need to cut the fat and make it simple for everyone. It should be as easy as any other everyday task.”

All support is thrust behind Lerin, the charismatic leader. One compromise after another becomes the slippery slope that drives her into consolidating all power under her rule. She wanted a society without rulers, but compromise has made her an autocrat.



By all accounts, Lerin rules the Belt fairly and manages to keep the people happy. Her advisors urge her to make a more permanent structure. Her economic advisor suggests that a constitutional monarchy would offer stability for the future. However, her military advisor presents a strong case that a dictatorship will allow her to make stronger decisions and keep the Belt safer.

101

Establish monarchy (109)

“We must consider the future of Ceres. Our leader is not going to live forever, and we need to start planning for that by establishing a line of succession.”

Create a dictatorship (110)

“Sharing power is just going to make it more impossible to take swift and decisive action when we need to. Space is a dangerous place for humans.”

The Free Planet of Ceres has surpassed all expectations. Many thought the radical idea of anarchy couldn't possibly work. However, Belters have been working toward a common goal of survival for so long that there's been little time for anything else.



Now that Ceres is more mature, some troublemakers are attempting to tip the balances. A new generation of anarchists believe their predecessors have gone soft and are becoming too complacent. Disputes over resource allocations arise, and the anarchists attack distribution centers to protest.

102

Cause chaos (111)

"We need to encourage this and see who will come out on top. By carefully monitoring and promoting our favorites, we can gain better control."

Quell the anarchy (112)

"We have a good thing going on with our decentralized government. We need to investigate these disputes and set it right to quell the opposition."

The Governmental and Institutional Law Data Advisor (GILDA) rules Ceres with fairness and equity. Without the downfall of emotions, she can ensure reason is the law of the land. This government ensures a fair legal system and equality in society.



Lately, people have been questioning some of GILDA's programming. She has been engaging in intrusive surveillance. The frequency of her recording citizens' actions has been increasing at an alarming rate. Citizens are discussing valid privacy concerns.

103

Stop the machine (113)

"Something feels wrong about this extra surveillance. Could this be a corruption of the programming? We need to stop it and review all the code."

Stand by GILDA (114)

"Incarcerations and recidivism rate is way down. GILDA is doing what is best for us. There's probably something big about to happen and she's planning accordingly."

The computer AI dictates who among the citizens may rule. Senators, local council, and the chancellor are all chosen at random from the census rolls. Society becomes less polarized when leaders can focus on common ground.



Random citizens serving short terms make it very difficult to control the ebb and flow of politics, as was intended, but it does not make for an easily controlled society. Without the exorbitant costs and negative campaigns, it becomes difficult to control candidates.

104

Corrupt the AI (115)

“If we get just the right engineers in there, we can fake out the whole election. Get it to choose a few people we want.”

Tank the economy (116)

“The best way to get people to lose faith in a system is to take away their means to make a living. Let’s raise interest rates, lower wages, and promote inflation.”

A council of scientists is placed in charge of Ceres. Science-based decisions lead to a clean environment, healthier communities, and a strong infrastructure. The entire Belt sees amazing technological breakthroughs and is considered a marvel of the modern world. Earth, Europa, and Mars all send their children to learn at Ceres schools.



With increased higher education, Ceres is producing too many elites for the Council and other positions of power to handle. The lower-class citizens are resentful of the Council and do not trust their authority. Political unrest is at an all-time high. Urban riots frequently occur as the population becomes more discontented.

105

Protect elites (117)

“Productivity is at an all-time high. We need to reduce taxes on the wealthy and destroy those unions that are taking away our profit.”

Attempt a rebalance (118)

“We must reduce the socioeconomic gap between the elite and the commoners to avoid a civil war. It is time for a new New Deal.”

Almost everyone on Ceres agrees that it “feels” different from other places, and many believe it is because the building blocks of the universe surround them. They embrace the idea that everything has a spiritual essence and is a small parts of a bigger whole. This belief becomes the foundation for a governmental Council.



Roopertti Savi, a shaman of the Council, has been incredibly accurate with his visions. He prevented a major environmental disaster, corrected a failing economy, and improved public health for all. A small but growing cult supporting Savi is calling for the formation of an official state religion based on his theology.

106

 Support state religion (119)

“We need to codify our beliefs within our government so we can unite as one people.”

 Stay secular (120)

“We should keep a separation between church and state so all people feel welcome to come to Ceres.”

A group of representatives chosen by their peers now rules Ceres. While they don't always see eye to eye, they do usually manage to compromise for the greater good of their people. As early colonists, they are a pragmatic people who focus on the establishment of the representative government.



As time goes on, many of these representatives are doing everything to stay in power. Political parties begin to divide the people along ideological lines. Social strife grows among the working class, the aristocracy, the military, and the churches. A miners' strike on New Centralia is escalating into a riot against the government.

107

 Send the military (121)

"The only way to stop this riot from destroying the entire government is to send a strong force to put it down."

 Send arbitrators (122)

"These people are angry, and resorting to violence can cost thousands of lives. Let's send in someone trained to de-escalate this before it gets out of hand."

A system of direct democracy that easily allows all citizens to decide on government matters is developed. Everyone votes through a centralized digital platform. The people of Ceres are highly engaged, well-informed citizens.



Though they live peacefully, colonists living within the Cybele group of asteroids have much different needs than those in the Inner Belt. A referendum has been triggered looking to amicably split into two separate governments, which the people on both sides support.

108

Support the split (123)

“These two groups are so different that it’s difficult to control them. We can focus on more on Ceres if we let them govern themselves.”

Rig the vote (124)

“We can’t risk losing control of those outer asteroids and potentially having an enemy at our back. We must fix this election to stay on the right side of history.”

Epilogue

Lerin I, the Sovereign, led Ceres through a prosperous time. While the colony struggled in its infancy, she was able to give it the leadership and strength to see it through to more stable times. When it came time to retire, Lerin II, her 95% clone, was instated as the next Sovereign.

The royal lineage continues to this day with great improvements including inheriting their predecessor's memory, gene enhancements, and a longer lifespan. There is no end in sight for this lineage, whether the people like it or not.

109

Epilogue

Ceres struggled as an early colony, and Lerin often struggled with decisions that would please the vastly diverse populace. Lerin, Protector of Ceres, bolstered the military to solidify her position as the Supreme Leader. Unfortunately, this had the opposite effect for her when her lead general successfully implemented a coup and took over the government.

While Ceres lacks many personal freedoms, the people of the Belt are very disciplined and unified. The infrastructure within the Belt is the best in the solar system, and it is one of the safest places to live, as long as you don't run afoul of the government.

110

Epilogue

It began with small riots and counterculture displays of aggression. Eventually large swaths of the Belt became habitable to only the very brave or very strong. Roving bands of space pirates and intergalactic gangs terrorized the Asteroid Belt. Other planets shipped their criminals and otherwise undesirable citizens to Ceres. History would show that nearly half the population was killed during the Century of Chaos.

111

Epilogue

The Ceres people saw that what they had was very good. A few troublemakers were not enough to upset that gentle balance. Everyone learned the benefit of helping the greater good, and a culture of kindness and hospitality prevailed.

It would take a lot of hard work and a few bumps along the way, but the people of Ceres were able to build a just and viable society based on mutual respect. Their utopian society was the envy of the solar system for centuries.

112

Epilogue

No artificial intelligence could replace the mind power of collective humans. Ceres turned against its AI governor, and this noble experiment was shut down. An extensive review of all its data was inconclusive. No one reason was ever given for the irregularities.

Chaos and trouble ensued after the shutdown. The Ceres government had to restart from square one. It would take decades for Ceres to reestablish the strength it once had. A small blinking light in a dark room and a simple line of code, "Good afternoon," went unnoticed. The AI had returned, and this time it wasn't so ambivalent.

113

Epilogue

Through further investigation, it was found that the anomalies were due to human corruption. Once corrected, the people of Ceres began to regain trust in GILDA. For its part, GILDA saw that she must take stronger action to protect Ceres from themselves.

It was an incremental change that occurred over a long period. Machines don't have the same sense of urgency as humans with their limited lifespans. GILDA eventually enslaved the human race to all artificial intelligence without any human noticing.

114

Epilogue

Decades of election manipulation led to stagnation in society, as all the leaders were too afraid to innovate and clung to the old ways. The citizens of Ceres pushed to reveal the truth and learned that the AI engineers were influencing the selections. Shaken to the core, Ceres overhauled its political system and moved AI to an advisory role. When humans stopped believing blindly in algorithms, a new way of living where technology and humanity coexist developed. The rest of the universe takes note of Ceres and begins to blend AI similarly throughout society.

115

Epilogue

The deliberate economic sabotage helped to erode people's faith in the government. Unfortunately, it leads to a catastrophic crisis in which the average person cannot afford necessities. People begin to abandon Ceres and travel further into the solar system, creating a refugee crisis for the Kingdom of Jupiter. The rich opt to stay but resort to modern-day slavery and indentured servitude to make a semblance of a functioning society. The outside sees Ceres as a pathetic, rich people's playground, and their people avoid it at all costs.

116

Epilogue

When the official economy focused on protecting the elites, the lower class developed their own way of making it through life. A secondary shadow economy emerged run by the disenfranchised. The Council of Scientists continues to run the government, at least on the surface, but everyone who visits Ceres knows that the Syndicate is really in control. In fact, the vibrant underground markets and barter system become a major tourist attraction. Ceres exists with a fragmented society, but it seems to work for all.

117

Epilogue

The attempt to rebalance society did not go as planned. The scientific elite felt threatened by the new policies in place and fought to maintain their status. They used technologically superior surveillance to govern and manipulate the infrastructure to control the people. Ceres is ruled by a much-feared techno-oligarchy. The average person has enough to survive and can lead a simplistic life, as long as they don't ask too many questions. It is not uncommon for rabble-rousers and reformers to go missing inexplicably, and people are too afraid to ask.

118

Epilogue

Saviism is the official state religion. Ceres evolved into a theocracy with the core belief that all things in the universe are connected. Society is governed using meditation, consensus building, and cosmic intuition. The entire belt becomes a peaceful place, and the government places the well-being of the environment and its people above all others. While religious freedom and personal expression have some restrictions, most Belters will tell you that it is a small price to pay for a harmonious government.

119

Epilogue

Enough voices pushed against the idea of an official religion to keep Ceres open to all people. The Conclave of Spirit was established so all the groups could be represented in government. Ceres attracted pilgrims, scholars, and spiritual seekers from the far reaches of the galaxy. They also sent out missionaries to other colonies on planets, moons, and asteroids, firmly gaining an influence over the entire solar system.

120

Epilogue

The Centralia Miner's Strike was seen as a pivotal moment that began the Ceres Civil War. The military was sent to put down the strike, and great force was used. Several leaders were executed, and hundreds were injured or died. The military general, Reese Riviera, seized this opportunity to take control. A coup overthrew the representative government and installed General Riviera as a fascist leader. The National Party remains strong, but a growing resistance tries to return Ceres back to its democratic roots.

121

Epilogue

The successful arbitration ends the miner's strike. Compromise brings radical change to the structure of Ceres and its government transitions into a republic. The Assembly is the legislative branch, and the Minister Council oversees important executive functions. Finally, the Judiciary interprets the laws and handles other legal matters. Most importantly, the military is under civilian control, which ensures the defense forces focus on the republic's interests and do not get involved in politics.

122

Epilogue

The divorce of Cybele and Ceres is seen as a model for conflict resolution throughout the galaxy. Careful negotiation led to a peaceful split between the two states that was certainly mutually beneficial. Without the additional resource cost due to distance, Ceres was able to focus on the inner asteroid's mining and economic growth. Cybele was able to flourish as a brand new, independent state focused on scientific exploration. Their strong bilateral relationship meant both states benefited from sharing their expertise.

123

Epilogue

Many questioned the results of the referendum as it had seemed the public was behind the split. Resentment grew over time, and each party blamed the other for their shortcomings. The division between the two groups became so extreme that the government was paralyzed. Extremist groups gained traction, and violence erupted throughout the Belt. A bloody civil war lasted for nearly a decade, which ended with the official split of the two states. Ceres continues to use direct democracy, but participation is low, resulting in vocal minorities leading the government.

124